

T20
ICC
WOMEN'S T20
WORLD CUP
ENGLAND & WALES 2020

Driving change: One of the minds behind The Hundred, Beth Barrett-Wild was later elevated to Director of the Women's Professional Game and eventually tournament director for the upcoming Women's T20 World Cup. GETTY IMAGES

iconic heroes of the players this summer because we want to introduce them to the world and for the world to fall in love with them. One of our key performance indicators is attendance. We're looking at 250,000-270,000 attendees this summer. We want to retain at least 36 per cent of them for England Women's internationals next year and are strategising around how to keep them coming back.

The other bit is that once demand is created, supply needs to be optimised. This summer, straight after the final at Lord's on July 5, we have the Test match against India starting on July 10. It's a different format, but still a marquee fixture. Ticket sales are already progressing encouragingly for that one. It will be a big showcase and an iconic one, given that it will be the first-ever women's Test hosted at the venue. We then have the Women's Domestic T20 Finals Day — the Vitality Blast — on July 17 at The Oval, and The Hundred from July 21.

Have any venues been upgraded for the tournament?

Bristol has invested several million pounds in converting its changing facilities. The city hosts a few double-headers, and the venue didn't have world-class changing rooms. So it built two new ones to add to the existing pair. Lancashire has poured some investment into Old Trafford. We know that while 36 per cent of ticket purchases are by females, it will probably end up being at least a 50-50 gender split among attendees. When they do come, venues often don't have enough female washrooms. Lancashire and Old Trafford had to double the number of female loos. We're also working on the recreational game. We have a £5 million county grants funding pot that supports grassroots facilities. This year, to celebrate and maximise the opportunity presented by the Women's T20 World Cup, that entire £5 million pot has been dedicated to facility and infrastructure improvements for women and girls.

You also advocate for bringing more women into leadership roles. What gaps still exist in that endeavour?

There is still a significant female leadership gap in cricket. There are certain things we can do and mandate from a governance perspective within the professional game. For example, we have board diversity targets. All our professional county clubs need to have a minimum of 40 per cent female board members. What that has not translated into yet is female chairpersons. We have one female chair, Tracey Orr at Warwickshire, who is brilliant. At the executive level, we currently have only one female chief executive within our professional structure. So there is a clear divide there. By 2027-28, we want to see women serving as chairs within the grassroots game and not just sitting on committees or acting as volunteer managers. We have the perfect platform, all the key ingredients and the willingness. It's all about execution now.